Patterns, local grammars, and the design of English teaching materials[1]

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This paper explores the applications of pattern grammar and local grammar in English language teaching, focusing specifically on the design of teaching materials. It shows that grammar patterns can be systematically analysed from a local grammar perspective, and further argues that the practice of local grammar analyses helps to raise language learners' awareness of the patterned nature of language in use and the close association between patterns and meanings. These in turn offer insights into materials writing. A sample coursebook unit is then offered to exemplify how pattern grammar and local grammar can be applied to derive pedagogical materials for English language teaching.

Introduction

This paper extends Hunston and Su's (2019) discussion about the pedagogical applications of pattern grammar and local grammar research in English language teaching. Briefly, Hunston and Su (2019) note two applications. One is to develop 'a thesaurus-like constructicon' so as to provide learners with combinations of lexis and grammar to express specific meanings, which has to some extent been explored in Su (2019). The other is to derive teaching materials, which is the focus of the present study. Specifically, this paper aims to outline an alternative approach to English language teaching for both materials writers and education practitioners.

Hunston (2002a: 167) suggests that awareness of patterns is crucial for English language learning 'because it facilitates the development of accuracy and fluency'. To develop teaching materials that can facilitate awareness-raising is thus necessary and worthwhile. This paper, bringing together pattern grammar and local grammar, offers an attempt to do so. It demonstrates that grammar patterns can be systematically analysed from a local grammar perspective and further argues that the practice of local grammar analysis helps to raise language learners' awareness of patterns and, more notably, the patterned nature of language in use. These in turn offer insights into the development of teaching materials. At this point, it should be noted that the primarily targeted learner group of the proposed teaching materials is advanced learners, partly because the practice of local grammar analysis requires sufficient knowledge of both lexicogrammar and discourse-semantics, and partly because advanced

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learners are more in a need of linguistic choices for meaning-making than grammatical rules for sentence-forming. A sample coursebook unit will also be offered to exemplify how pattern grammar and local grammar can be applied to derive pedagogical materials for English language teaching.

Pattern grammar and local grammar

Pattern grammar is an approach to language description that prioritizes the phraseological behaviour of individual lexical items (Hunston and Francis 2000). It shares the view with other functional approaches to grammar that lexis and grammar are inseparable (e.g. Halliday and Matthiessen 2004; Hoey 2005), which, at the same time, distinguishes it from traditional approaches to grammar (Su 2019). The most notable observation drawn in pattern grammar is that patterns and meanings are associated. For example, Francis, Hunston, and Manning (1996, 1998), offering a comprehensive list of patterns associated with verbs, adjectives, and nouns, show that words occurring in a given pattern can be divided into a (limited) set of meaning groups. Hunston and Francis (2000: 83–149) further present two pieces of evidence supporting the close connection between patterns and meanings: (a) different senses of a word tend to occur in different patterns; and (b) words occurring in the same pattern share meaning aspects.

The concept of local grammar has been comprehensively discussed by, for example, Hunston and Su (2019) and Cheng and Ching (2018). Put succinctly, local grammar is an alternative approach, as opposed to general grammars, to linguistic analysis and explanation. Each local grammar seeks to account for one meaning or function only; as such, each local grammar offers a specialized description of that targeted meaning or function (Hunston and Su, 2019). The defining feature which distinguishes local grammars from traditional or general grammars is that the relationship between syntactic elements is accounted for in functional-pragmatic terminologies, rather than in traditional grammatical ones such as subject, object, etc. (see Su and Wei (2018) for more discussion). For the purpose of illustration, Table 1 gives examples of local grammar analyses.

Table 1 shows that, from a local grammar perspective, each syntactic or utterance unit is analysed using a transparent and context-specific terminology (e.g. *She* was analysed as the 'target', i.e. the person/thing being evaluated, in *She was good at raising money*), thereby contributing to the transparency and specificity of the description (Su 2019; Su and Wei 2018). This, in turn, suggests that local grammar descriptions can be more

TABLE 1.
Local grammar analyses of 'evaluation' (adapted from Hunston and Su 2019)

Target	Hinge	Evaluation	Action
She	*was*	*good*	*at raising money*
Mr Gates	*has been*	*hugely successful*	*in creating a world-leading business*
Target	**Hinge**	**Evaluation**	**Specifier**
Celery seed extracts	*are*	*helpful*	*in the treatment of arthritis*
The Griffins	*were*	*very generous*	*with offers of lifts*

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informative for language teaching, because, arguably, it is more useful to know an element in terms of its discourse or communicative function than in grammatical terms (see also Hunston 2002b: 157).

The observation that patterns and meanings are associated suggests that grammar patterns can be a good starting point for developing local grammars, because searching grammar patterns facilitates the identification of specific meanings in corpora and local grammars are dedicated to describing such meanings, as discussed above. This has been made particularly explicit in Hunston (2002a: 181), where she notes that grammar patterns 'are an essential component of Local Grammars'. Hunston and Su (2019), focusing on evaluation realized by adjective patterns, have further demonstrated that grammar patterns can indeed facilitate the development of local grammars.

This paper therefore presents a pattern-based approach to developing local grammars, bearing in mind that the ultimate aim is to explore the pedagogical applications of pattern grammar and local grammar. In general, the proposed approach, i.e. combining pattern grammar and local grammar, is largely consistent with the functional approaches to English language teaching which view language primarily as a means for social communication and grammar as a resource for meaning-making (e.g. Halliday and Matthiessen 2004). The importance and usefulness of functional approaches in foreign language teaching has been increasingly recognized. Saraceni (2008: 171), for example, notes that foreign language learners can benefit from the view that grammar and meaning are interdependent, because grammar will no longer be seen 'as a set of rules but as something that helps them express their ideas'.

The feasibility of the proposed approach relies heavily upon the *Grammar Pattern* series (Francis et al. 1996, 1998). While these reference books are now out of print, they have recently been made freely available online at https://www.collinsdictionary.com/grammar.patterns, thus the kind of analysis outlined below can be practised by materials writers, language teachers, and learners. The two reference books provide a comprehensive list of grammar patterns for scrutiny, listing approximately 90 verb patterns, 70 noun patterns, and 40 adjectives patterns that are observed in the Bank of English. These offer a good resource for practising local grammar analyses, which in turn helps to raise language leaners' awareness of the patterned nature of language in use. Below I first demonstrate how to undertake local grammar analyses of grammar patterns and then further discuss how this can inform the design of pedagogical materials for English language teaching.

A pattern-based approach to local grammars

Because of space constraints, only one pattern is selected and analysed for the purpose of demonstration. The pattern is **V n as n** (Francis et al. 1996: 348–55), as in *His critics depict him as a control freak*.

Before moving on, it is necessary to discuss one major methodological issue concerning local grammar research, i.e. the identification of terminologies for local grammar analyses. Because local grammars use transparent and context-specific terms to analyse corresponding formal elements, the selection of local grammar terminologies should strictly

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follow the principles that the terminologies should, first, be proposed within the specific context of the targeted meaning or function; and, second, explicitly reflect the discoursal or pragmatic function of the element being analysed (see Su (2019) for more discussion).

It will become clear that in most cases the selection of local grammar terminologies for each analysis can be justified by the meaning or function realized (cf. Hunston and Su 2019: 572). I will therefore not explain the terminologies used in the subsequent analyses unless it is necessary. One terminology needs to be explained at the outset, though, is that of Hinge, which is used to label those elements which do not have a specific pragmatic meaning but link together different parts. The prepositions *as* in the selected verb pattern, for example, is analysed as Hinge. Additionally, all the examples used in the subsequent analyses unless otherwise noted are taken either from Francis et al. (1996) or the Bank of English.

The local grammar analyses of the pattern **V n *as* n** suggest three general meaning groups: 'Classify', 'Cause interpretation', 'Career-duration'. It is worth noting that meaning groups proposed in the present study for the pattern are not necessarily, nor should they be, consistent with those identified in Francis et al. (1996), since the bases for the groupings are different: the groupings proposed in this paper are informed by local grammar analyses while those in Francis et al. (1996) are analyst- or researcher-driven, relying upon native speakers' intuition or common sense.

The major meaning group identified is 'Classify', in which verbs indicate an Actor classifies, usually has the connotation of evaluation, an Entity, be it human on non-human, in terms of a particular Role, as shown in Table 2. For the purpose of further illustration, a couple of verbs have been selectively listed to illustrate each meaning group, which applies throughout the analyses.

The second meaning group identified is that of 'Cause interpretation', which has two types. The difference between them is that in one the noun following the verb indicates the Entity being interpreted whereas in the other it indicates the Interpreter—the person who interprets, as shown in Table 3 and 4, respectively.

Verbs in the third group are associated with the meaning of 'Career-duration', indicating what a Career-holder has been doing or is going to do as his/her career (e.g. *begin* or *end*). The analyses are shown in Table 5.

The above discussion has presented the local grammar analyses of one selected verb pattern. The analyses, together with Su (2019), should have shown the feasibility of analysing grammar patterns from a local

TABLE 2.
Local grammar analyses of 'Classify'

Classifier	Classify	Entity-classified	Hinge	Role
Players	*acclaim*	*Fagan*	*as*	*one of the greatest managers*
She	*characterized*	*him*	*as*	*a gossip, a liar*
e.g. classify, conceptualize, perceive				

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TABLE 3.
Local grammar analyses of 'Cause interpretation'

Evidence	Cause interpretation	Entity-interpreted	Hinge	Interpretation
His aspirations	*Mark*	*him*	*as*	*the last of an old breed*
His experience	*... qualifies*	*him*	*as*	*a leading authority*
e.g. mark, qualify, stamp				

TABLE 4.
Local grammar analyses of 'Cause interpretation'

Entity-interpreted	Cause interpretation	Interpreter	Hinge	Interpretation
You	*strike*	*me*	*as*	*being a puzzle person*
He	*doesn't impress*	*me*	*as*	*a statesman*
e.g. impress, strike				

TABLE 5.
Local grammar analyses of 'Career-duration'

Career-holder	Career-duration	Career ...	Hinge	... Career
Lloyd Wright	*began*	*his career*	*as*	*a landscape architect*
He	*ended*	*his career*	*as*	*Leader of the Opposition*
e.g. end, continue, start				

TABLE 6.
Local grammar analyses of 'Inform'

Informer	Inform	Addressee	Hinge	Message
People	*told*	*me*	*that*	*there was no job harder than nursing*
He	*advised*	*Nikham*	*that*	*the agents had changed their travel plans*
e.g. inform, instruct, notify				

grammar perspective, thereby facilitating the development of local grammars. The analyses of the pattern **V n *as* n**, for example, identified three specific meanings and led to three corresponding local grammars. It should be noted that overlapping meaning groups across patterns are very likely to be found if more patterns are analysed. Adjective patterns, for example, have been shown to be predominantly associated with evaluation (Hunston and Su 2019). This suggests that the analyses of grammar patterns listed in Francis et al. (1996, 1998) would result in a manageable number of local grammars. These local grammars, each defined by a specific meaning, might in turn contribute to 'a thesaurus-like constructicon' (Hunston and Su 2019).

More notably, this suggests a way to incorporate pattern grammar and local grammar into the design of pedagogical materials for English language teaching, as discussed below.

Incorporating pattern grammar and local grammar into the design of teaching materials

Hunston and Su (2019) have briefly discussed how grammar patterns and local grammars can be used to derive English language teaching materials. This section explores further how to do so. The overall argument made is that materials informed by pattern grammar and local grammar would be

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TABLE 7.
Local grammar analyses of 'Cause interpretation'

Evidence	Cause interpretation	Interpreter	Hinge	Interpretation
My experience	*Tells*	*me*	*that*	*we do not all have all the necessary skills*
The picture	*Showed*	*us*	*that*	*Stapleton was indeed a Baskerville*
e.g. convince, show, teach				

TABLE 8.
Local grammar analyses of 'Cause emotion'

Emoter	Cause emotion	Emoter	Hinge	Trigger
They	*should satisfy*	*themselves*	*that*	*they know exactly what they are buying*
... government	*can flatter*	*itself*	*that*	*much of the trouble is encouraging*
e.g. comfort, delude, flatter				

designed primarily to raise learners' awareness of the patterned nature of language in use.

While it is essential to analyse all the patterns listed in Francis et al. (1996, 1998) so as to fully develop what Hunston and Su (2019) call 'a thesaurus-like constructicon', materials writers and/or education practitioners do not need to do so. What is more important is to raise language learners' awareness of the phraseological tendency or the patterned nature of language in use. Teaching materials informed by pattern grammar and local grammar could, for example, be organized around the following aspects: (a) introduce a grammar pattern, (b) retrieve instances of the selected pattern, (c) perform sample analyses so as to identify a set of appropriate local grammar terminologies, (d) summarize the analyses and establish local grammars, and (e) exercises. These are further discussed below.

Francis et al. (1996, 1998) would be useful for presenting information about grammar patterns, thus in a way responding to the invitation of Hunston and Francis (2000: 272) to look 'forward to information about patterns being incorporated in language teaching materials'. Instances instantiating a given pattern can be retrieved by searching that pattern in any part-of-speech (PoS)-tagged corpora. PoS tagging is not a difficult task, as many corpus tools or online platforms (e.g. SketchEngine, BNC-web) are equipped with this functionality, though tagging errors might be inevitable. As for local grammar analyses, the difficult task is to identify appropriate terminologies. The terminologies would be acceptable as long as they are proposed within the specific context of that targeted meaning, as discussed earlier. Finally, extra exercises provide learners with chances to further interact with more data, knowing better how patterns are used to convey meanings in contexts. Extra exercises would also facilitate learners' vocabulary-learning, especially because these extend their vocabulary for talking about specific topics (see also Hunston and Francis 2000: 278). Such teaching materials, arguably, can substantially help to raise language learners' awareness of patterns and the patterned nature of language in use.

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A sample coursebook unit based on the pattern **V n that** is offered below, aiming to further exemplify how to incorporate pattern grammar and local grammar research into English language teaching materials. The data used for the exemplification are taken from the BNC. BNC is used here because of its free availability, such that materials writers and English language teachers and/or learners can practise what is discussed below. At this point, it should be said that what is outlined below are only the major sections and the content each section may contain, serving as guidelines, rather than a script, to develop the kind of teaching materials proposed. In other words, the sections outlined here can be adapted in the practice of materials writing and language teaching, which in turn gives more flexibility to both material writers and education practitioners.

Section I: introducing V n that

Verbs occurring in this pattern are followed by a noun and a that-clause; for example:

(1) The Brigade Major *informed me that* the Brigadier's party would be in the restaurant.
(2) We *warn them that* their lives are in danger.

The passive pattern is ***be* V-ed that**; for example:

(3) She *has been told that* members of the Lords are permitted to use the facilities.
(4) Mrs Thatcher *has been advised that* a complete ban on strikes is not a practical proposition.

Section II: data retrieval

1. Compose and refine the query script. To retrieve instances of **V n that** in the BNC, a possible search sequence is '_VV* (_NP0 | _PN*) that_CJT'[2].
2. Retrieve instances by searching the query script composed[3].

Section III: local grammar analyses

1. Look at the concordance lines given in Figure 1.
2. Practise local grammar analyses using appropriate terminologies.

Verbs of this pattern are associated with three meaning groups: 'Inform', 'Cause interpretation', and 'Cause emotion'. Each needs to be analysed using a specific set of terminologies, as discussed in more detail below.

1) The majority of verbs co-occurring with the pattern are associated with the meaning 'Inform'. These verbs indicate that an Informer informs the Addressee a Message; for example,
   (5) People [Informer] told [Inform] me [Addressee] that [Hinge] there is no job harder than nursing [Message].

2) Verbs associated with the meaning 'Cause interpretation' indicate that an Interpreter presents an Interpretation of the Evidence; for example:
   (6) Experience [Evidence] has taught [Cause interpretation] us [Interpreter] that [Hinge] it has not been necessary to invoke the similar or parallel provisions made for those industries [Interpretation].

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FIGURE 1.
Sample concordance lines of **V n that**

1	way to make a living: [People	told me that	there was no job harder than nursing
2	said Henry. [The experts	assure us that	symptoms occur between one and four
3	face-value: H.D. may have honestly	persuaded herself that	she was the great (though virginal)
4	, which keeps track of such things,	tells us that	this too will be overshot, resulting in
5	. We met one of the Medics who	informed me that	the bodies of Les and the other three
6	He wished us the best of luck and	advised us that	the Brigade was here to stay. [
7	The Tories have been	comforting themselves that	they are holding their own in marginal
8	know about. For the first time he	told himself that	he was fully at home in his work
9	The Warden (Vice-Chancellor) Duff	assured them that	he was now not nearly so odd as
10	part, however small, and he may	remind her that	he can go back to Bangladesh and marry
11	at Stevenage Town Hall we	told Ralph that	we expected some money for these. He
12	I left the railway station, the police	warned me that	there was a small demonstration against
13	The exercises	taught me that	when things go wrong you need to take
14	explores the nature of salvation. He	tells us that	God 's salvation is not dependent on our
15	. On the other hand, Gina had	assured him that	he was doing publicity photographs for
16	who try to barnstorm my classes I	inform them that	my classes are intended for Japanese
17	the briefly open door. The blaze	reminded him that	he was beginning to feel cold. Well
18	they should	satisfy themselves that	they know exactly what they are buying
19	Experience has	taught us that	it has not been necessary to invoke the
20	this month 's What 's New pages will	show you that	we 've acknowledged the error of our

3) Verbs associated with the meaning 'Cause emotion' indicate that an Emoter has a particular emotion based on his/her thought or idea which can be labelled Trigger; for example,

(7) They [Emoter] should satisfy [Cause emotion] themselves [Emoter] that [Hinge] they know exactly what they are buying [Trigger].

Section IV: establish local grammars

Based on the analyses, three local grammars, defined by 'Inform', 'Cause interpretation', and 'Cause emotion', respectively, can be established and those verbs which are associated with each meaning can be identified, as shown in Tables 6–8.

Section V: exercises

1. Retrieve more instances of the pattern **V n that** and analyse these instances using the local grammar terminologies identified.
2. Find as many verbs as possible which can be used to, for example, inform someone a message.

The procedures outlined above are replicable for analysing other grammar patterns listed in Francis et al. (1996, 1998). This means that, on the one hand, material writers can adapt the procedures when developing teaching materials. On the other hand, this provides a guideline for English language teachers and learners to develop their own 'self-access materials' (Tomlinson, 2011) and, furthermore, to practise the local grammar analyses themselves, allowing them to get hands-on experience (see also O'Keeffe, McCarthy and Carter 2007: 24). Once the learners have become familiar with this kind of analysis, they can work on more patterns either independently or collaboratively. While learners of, for example, intermediate level may not be motivated to engage with the kind of analysis presented above, advanced learners, i.e. the primarily targeted learner group, would be, because they are in a need

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of linguistic repertoire for meaning-making, as noted earlier. Another potential benefit of this is that it enables learners to explore language learning outside the classroom, which is important because 'all too often the language classroom is viewed as a kind of artificial world detached from reality, and therefore anything that helps bridge this gap should be welcomed' (Saraceni 2008: 171–72).

Overall, English language teaching materials based on pattern grammar and local grammar research should be designed to facilitate the generalization of lexicogrammatical resources available to express specific meanings in communication and, more importantly, to raise learners' awareness of the patterned nature of language in use. Such materials, focusing on specifying the use and meaning of specific lexicogrammatical patterns, are intended to supplement existing teaching materials, especially those which focus on the teaching of grammatical rules. Arguably, the combination of these pedagogical materials can possibly realize the aim, and justify the claim, that '[m]astering a language means mastering the ability to use language forms for particular purposes in a variety of social contexts, in a way that is not just grammatical, but appropriate and effective' (Keck and Kim 2014: 36).

Conclusion

This paper has presented a possible way to incorporate pattern grammar and local grammar into the design of English language teaching materials. It has been shown that grammar patterns can be systematically analysed from a local grammar perspective. It has been further argued that the practice of local grammar analyses of grammar patterns can benefit learners by raising their awareness of the patterned nature of language in use and the association between patterns and meanings. These in turn suggest that pattern grammar and local grammar can be usefully applied to derive pedagogical materials for English language teaching, as exemplified in the sample coursebook unit.

In the context of English as a lingua franca, a large population are learning English and most of them have, more or less, difficulties expressing and conveying meanings in English in an appropriate way. To offer (EFL) learners various materials that could facilitate their English language learning is thus desirable. The kind of materials suggested in this paper would be one possible candidate among many others, as such to develop such teaching materials, to use them and to further explore how effective the materials can be for English language teaching, would be tasks worth undertaking.

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Notes

1 This study is based on the project *The Semantic Labelling of Grammar Patterns*. The project was led by Professor Susan Hunston at the University of Birmingham, and I worked on it as a Research Associate. The study has also benefited considerably from reviewers' comments. Any remaining errors are mine.

2 A point worth noting here is that the search of a given pattern is dependent upon the tagging system used in the targeted corpus. The searching script composed here is based on the tagset used in the BNC. Details of the tagging system can be found at http://ucrel.lancs.ac.uk/bnc2/bnc2guide.htm#tagset.

3 The primary purpose of this step is to get as many instances of a given pattern as possible, as such recall (how many instances can be retrieved by searching the script) and precision (how many instances retrieved are 'real' instantiation of a given pattern), though they should be carefully considered in data retrieval, become less important.

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